

The Not For You Page: Algorithmic Design for User Disengagement

Abstract. Algorithmic recommendation systems across modern digital platforms are predominantly engineered to maximize user engagement, retention, and time on platform. While effective for commercial metrics, these continuous feed architectures frequently lead to digital fatigue, compulsive consumption, and diminished user agency. This paper explores the concept of the “Not For You Page” (NFYP), an alternative feed model designed to investigate how recommendation systems can be re-oriented toward disengagement and user well-being. By examining mechanisms that introduce intentional friction and alter content distribution, this research evaluates how algorithmic design can encourage voluntary platform exit. The project addresses the feasibility of embedding digital well-being directly into recommendation logic, offering a counter perspective to traditional retention focused platform architectures.

1. Introduction

Feed-based recommendation engines serve as the foundational interface for modern content discovery. Driven by retention metrics, these architectures continuously adapt to user behavior to capture and sustain attention. However, the systematic optimization of screen time increasingly conflicts with user autonomy, giving rise to digital burnout and cognitive overload. Current interventions for digital well-being rely almost exclusively on external controls, such as application timers or system level access restrictions, leaving the underlying algorithms largely unexamined as tools for self-regulation.

To address this issue, this project examines the “Not For You Page” (NFYP), a conceptual recommendation model that inverts conventional retention objectives. Rather than reinforcing engagement loops, the system explores methods

to systematically reduce content resonance and introduce friction as usage continues. This research investigates the theoretical foundation of anti-retention algorithm design, outlining potential mechanisms for disengagement and discussing their broader implications for human-computer interaction and ethical platform development.

1.1. Related work

Research on TikTok’s recommendation system has documented how its algorithm is explicitly engineered around engagement maximization. Zhou [6] shows that TikTok blends collaborative and content-based filtering to personalize content delivery, but finds that this comes at the cost of content homogeneity and low algorithmic transparency.

This engagement-first design has been linked to a range of documented harms. Smith and Short [5] provide psychometric evidence of problematic TikTok use, with withdrawal and relapse emerging as the strongest predictive criteria and loneliness positively associated with maladaptive use patterns. Beyond behavioral addiction, Ionescu and Licu [3] review evidence that, over time, algorithmically curated feeds shape users’ self-perceived identity and personal values. At a societal level, Kuncoro and Hasanah [4] argue that the same engagement-maximizing logic can create echo chambers that reinforce radical or extremist views by continuously amplifying content that sustains user attention regardless of its ideological content.

In parallel, human-computer interaction research has explored interventions for digital well-being, but almost exclusively at the interface layer rather than within the recommendation logic itself. Haliburton et al. [2] show that short, interface-level design frictions can reduce compulsive app-opening behavior over time, while Almoallim and Sas [1] find that the most popular digital well-being applications rely almost entirely on screen-time monitoring and externally imposed usage limits, without modifying the underlying recommendation algorithm.

Taken together, this literature establishes both that TikTok-style algorithms are explicitly optimized for engagement and that this optimization carries documented costs to individual behavior, identity, and public discourse. Yet the interventions proposed to date treat well-being as something to protect through external, interface-level controls, never by reorienting the recommendation objective itself. The Not For You Page addresses this gap directly.

2. Methodology

2.1. Methodology subsection

Your methodology

3. Results

A	B	C
A1	B1	C1
A2	B2	C2
A3	B3	C3
A4	B4	C4

Table 1. The summary of the table

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4. Discussion

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Acknowledgment

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